increased and it made attempts to improve relations with China, including further agreements on border management in 2012 and 2013. Beginning in the early 2000s, trade relations between India and China grew from a negligible amount to $73 billion in 2012. People-to-people contacts also increased, and India and China identified aspects of a shared agenda.

During this period, New Delhi and Beijing held similar positions on climate agreements proposed by Europe and the United States, and they cooperated as part of the BASIC coalition (Brazil, South Africa, India and China). In negotiations with the United States, this group brokered a tentative outcome at the 2009 Copenhagen Climate Summit, one they believed protected the interests of developing economies. Similarly, both India and China lobbied for greater voting shares at international financial institutions, and eventually collaborated on the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) and the BRICS New Development Bank (comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa), where they could exert greater influence on institutional lending. [6] At the United Nations Security Council, the two countries shared similar concerns about humanitarian intervention, sovereignty, and the Responsibility to Protect (R2P) commitment. [7] These efforts, and particularly the involvement of India in BRICS, allowed India to exchange the rhetoric of developing world solidarity for that of an emerging major power.

During this period, India also increased formal trade and economic ties with Asian economies. After having entered into trade agreements with the likes of Sri Lanka, Thailand, and Singapore in the late 1990s, India finalized more ambitious trade deals with larger economic entities—the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), South Korea, and Japan —between 2009 and 2014. A trade agreement was also contemplated with China. But in time, India’s trade deficits widened with these Asian economies and in some cases, as with Japan, the volumes of direct trade flattened. In India, this led to growing concerns that it had not benefited sufficiently from these trade agreements. [8]

The years between 2009 and 2014—marked by scepticism of closer relations with the United States and its European allies, closer coordination